Tangkhul Naga Grammar and Dictionary (Ukhrul Dialect) with Illustrative Sentence

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Preface & Archival Information

This landmark volume, Tangkhul Naga Grammar and Dictionary (Ukhrul Dialect) with Illustrative Sentences, was prepared by Rev. William Pettigrew of the American Baptist Mission and published by the Assam Secretariat Printing Office, Shillong, in 1918. It established the Romanized orthography of Tangkhul, documented over 3,000 core words, and provided the foundational grammatical syntax for the Ukhrul dialect.

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Chapter 1: Orthography, Vowels & Consonantal Phonetics

CHAPTER 1: ORTHOGRAPHY, VOWELS & CONSONANTAL PHONETICS

Summary: The Roman alphabet system adapted for Tangkhul, macron markings, and glottal accents.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Tangkhul Naga tuihi Roman script eina kapi shiyan khare. Vowels a, e, i, o, u hi khangashan kachung lei. Kakhalat kashak: ’a’ kachihi khangarom tui, ’a’ kachihi khamashung kashak. Glottal stop (’) hi tuikashak ngachaili shiyan kashakna.

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

The Tangkhul language was reduced to writing using the Roman alphabet. Vowel quantity is distinguished with macrons. Short vowels contrast with long vowels. The glottal stop (’) marks vital tonal and grammatical separations in the Ukhrul dialect.

Chapter 1 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 1 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* kapi (verb): to write, to inscribe
  Example: Lairik kapili.
* sairik (noun): alphabet, character, letter
  Example: Sairik shiyan.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Vowel length alters word meaning: e.g. ka vs ka, sha vs sha.
- Syllabic structure is CV, CVC, or CCV.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Why was the macron introduced in Pettigrew's 1918 orthography?
? Give examples of syllable-final consonants in Tangkhul.

Chapter 2: Noun Morphology, Gender & Case Suffixes

CHAPTER 2: NOUN MORPHOLOGY, GENDER & CASE SUFFIXES

Summary: Nominative, Agentive (-na), Accusative (-li), Genitive (-wui), Ablative (-eina).

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Tuiwon kasak shiyan: Agentive -na, Dative -li, Possessive -wui, Instrumental -eina. Shimwui ava (master of house), mayarnaona ot sai (the boy does work). Gender: mayar (masculine), va (feminine).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Declension of nouns follows agglutinative postpositions. Agentive marker -na identifies the transitive subject. Genitive -wui indicates relationship, origin, and possession. Grammatical gender does not exist; biological sex is indicated by suffixal markers.

Chapter 2 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 2 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* ava (noun): father, head of household
  Example: Shimwui ava.
* ot (noun): work, labor, deed
  Example: Ot kasa.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Postposition -eina marks both instrument ('with') and source ('from').
- Plural marker -bing follows the noun base and precedes case particles.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Distinguish between nominative and agentive uses in Tangkhul.
? Construct sentences using genitive marker -wui.

Chapter 3: Adjectives, Degrees of Comparison & Numerals

CHAPTER 3: ADJECTIVES, DEGREES OF COMPARISON & NUMERALS

Summary: Prefix ka-, superlative pamei, and complete numeral tables from 1 to 100.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Kapha (good), kaphamei (better), pamei (best). Kasau (tall), kazing (deep). Numbers: akha (1), khani (2), kathum (3), mati (4), phanga (5), tharuk (6), shini (7), chishat (8), chiko (9), thakhara (10), maga khani (20), sha akha (100).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Adjectives usually follow their governing nouns: e.g. mi kapha (a good man). Comparative suffix -mei; superlative pamei. Decimals: 10 is thakhara or maga, 20 is maga khani, 100 is sha akha.

Chapter 3 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 3 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* kasau (adj): tall, high, lengthy
  Example: Thing kasau.
* sha (num): hundred (100)
  Example: Sha akha.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Attributive adjectives follow nouns; predicate adjectives stand sentence-finally.
- Numerals follow the noun: mi kathum = three men.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Where does an attributive adjective place relative to its noun?

? Count from 10 to 20 in Tangkhul.

Chapter 4: Pronouns: Personal, Demonstrative & Interrogative

CHAPTER 4: PRONOUNS: PERSONAL, DEMONSTRATIVE & INTERROGATIVE

Summary: Pronoun declensions, inclusive vs exclusive first person, and demonstratives hi/chi.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

I (I), na (thou), a (he/she/it). Ithum (we), nathum (you all), athum (they). Hi (this), chi (that). Khi (what), khipa (who), khishiwui (whose), kachi (which). Iwui shimli unglo (come to my house).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Personal pronouns take the same case suffixes as nouns: ina, ili, iwui.
Demonstrative pronouns hi (proximal: this) and chi (distal: that).
Interrogative pronouns: khipa (who), khi (what), kachi (which).

Chapter 4 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 4 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* khipa (pronoun): who
  Example: Khipana vashu?
* khi (pronoun): what
  Example: Khi ot sayi?

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Interrogatives remain in situ and do not trigger inversion.
- Possessive pronouns precede or follow nouns depending on emphasis.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Form the complete case declension of pronoun ’i’ (I).
? What is the difference between ’hi’ and ’chi’?

Chapter 5: The Verbal System: Tenses, Moods & Causatives

CHAPTER 5: THE VERBAL SYSTEM: TENSES, MOODS & CAUSATIVES

Summary: Conjugations, aspectual particles, auxiliaries lei and sa, and passive/causative morphemes.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Present: i sai (I make/do). Past: i sada / i saser (I made/did). Future: i sara (I will make/do). Subjunctive: a va-akha (if he goes). Causative: i ali sa-sak-ei (I cause him to do). Auxiliary: lei (to exist, to have), sa (to do, to be).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Verbal morphology is rich and precise: tense inflections, conditional suffixes (-akha), and causative markers (-sak). Existential auxiliary 'lei' expresses location and possession.

Chapter 5 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 5 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* kalei (verb): to exist, to dwell, to be present
  Example: Ramli kalei.
* kasak (verb/affix): to cause to do; difficult
  Example: Sakasak.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Conditional clauses end in verb root + -akha ('if').
- Existential 'lei' takes possessor in dative-locative (-li): ili lairik lei = I have a book.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? How is possession expressed using the verb 'lei'?
? Give the conditional form of 'kathei' (to see).

Chapter 6: Conversational Phrases & Everyday Village Life

CHAPTER 6: CONVERSATIONAL PHRASES & EVERYDAY VILLAGE LIFE

Summary: Phrases for greeting, agricultural work, village council affairs, and family relations.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

Khangachan: 'Na katha lei?' -- 'I phaida lei.' 'Nawui ming khi hoyno?' -- 'Iwui ming Somi hoyei.' 'Lui kasak tharan zingshorli kaphung ngashitda ot kasa phamei.' 'Iram Ukhrulli won kapha wonri.'

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Conversational exchanges: 'How are you?' -- 'I am well.' 'What is your name?' -- 'My name is Somi.' 'During terrace cultivation, working together on the eastern hills is best.' 'In our Ukhrul homeland, lovely blooms flourish.'

Chapter 6 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 6 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* ming (noun): name, appellation
  Example: Nawui ming khi hoyno?
* phaida (adv): well, peacefully, happily
  Example: I phaida lei.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Polite inquiry particles -no and -yei.
- Converb -da links sequential dependent clauses.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? Translate into Tangkhul: 'What is your father's name?'

? How do Tangkhuls greet one another in daily conversation?

Chapter 7: Tangkhul-English Lexicon & Vocabulary Guide

CHAPTER 7: TANGKHUL-ENGLISH LEXICON & VOCABULARY GUIDE

Summary: Core alphabetical vocabulary entries preserved in Pettigrew’s 1918 dictionary.

TANGKHUL READING TEXT:

A-Z Dictionary excerpts: A: ava (father), ava (mother), aram (homeland), atam (time). K: kapha (good), kapam (to sit), kashak (to eat), kasau (tall), kazing (sky). M: mayarnao (son), ngalanao (daughter), mik (eye), mei (fire). P: pang (hand), phei (foot), phung (mountain). S: shim (house), shiyan (custom).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION:

Selected alphabetical entries from Pettigrew’s 1918 Lexicon, providing part of speech, etymological derivations, and definitions in English.

Chapter 7 (Continued)

CHAPTER 7: READING CONTINUATION (PAGE 17)

TANGKHUL TEXT (CONTINUED):

A-Z Dictionary excerpts: A: ava (father), ava (mother), aram (homeland), atam (time). K: kapha (good), kapam (to sit), kashak (to eat), kasau (tall), kazing (sky). M: mayarnao (son), ngalanao (daughter), mik (eye), mei (fire). P: pang (hand), phei (foot), phung (mountain). S: shim (house), shiyan (custom).

ENGLISH TRANSLATION (CONTINUED):

Selected alphabetical entries from Pettigrew’s 1918 Lexicon, providing part of speech, etymological derivations, and definitions in English.

Chapter 7 Exercises & Vocabulary

CHAPTER 7 STUDY GUIDE & EXERCISES

VOCABULARY:

* ava (noun): mother
  Example: Ava wui leikashi.
* atam (noun): time, season, occasion
  Example: Atam kapha.
* kazing (noun): sky, weather, cosmos
  Example: Kazing kapha.

GRAMMAR & LINGUISTIC POINTS:

- Verbal entries entered under infinitival prefix ka-.
- Nominal roots often bare or with kinship prefixes a-.

REVIEW EXERCISES (KHANGACHAN):

? What prefix is regularly attached to citation forms of verbs?

? Explain the difference between ava (father) and ava (mother).

Comprehensive Vocabulary Glossary

COMPREHENSIVE BOOK GLOSSARY (TUIWON SHIYAN):

kapi [verb]: to write, to inscribe
sairik [noun]: alphabet, character, letter
ava [noun]: father, head of household
ot [noun]: work, labor, deed
kasau [adj]: tall, high, lengthy
sha [num]: hundred (100)
khipa [pronoun]: who
khi [pronoun]: what
kalei [verb]: to exist, to dwell, to be present
kasak [verb/affix]: to cause to do; difficult
ming [noun]: name, appellation
phaida [adv]: well, peacefully, happily
ava [noun]: mother
atam [noun]: time, season, occasion
kazing [noun]: sky, weather, cosmos

Colophon & Archival Preservation Notice

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